How BARCS Finds Important Genes

Chapter 1: The ideas

Counts, proportions, noise and the design matrix

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About this guide. This guide explains how the BARCS computer program works. You need only arithmetic, fractions, percents, powers and square roots. The guide teaches logarithms when it uses them. Both chapters use the same small set of numbers, so you can follow every step. The guide uses the writing rules of ASD-STE100 Simplified Technical English.

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The experiment: a CRISPR screen

Each cell in your body has about 20,000 genes. A gene is a set of instructions. Scientists want to know which genes a cell needs, for example to survive a cancer drug.

A **CRISPR screen** tests thousands of genes at the same time. It works in four steps:

1. Scientists make a **library** of short pieces of RNA, called **guides**. Each guide switches off one gene.
2. They put one guide into each cell. Now each cell has one gene switched off.
3. They grow the cells. Some cells grow under normal conditions (**control**). Other cells grow with a drug (**drug**).
4. A sequencing machine reads the guides in each group. The machine counts how many times it reads each guide. This number is a **read count**.

If cells need a gene to survive the drug, the cells that lose that gene die. Their guide becomes rare in the drug group. So the guide count goes down.

Remember

BARCS does not look at cells directly. It looks at read counts. A guide that becomes rare tells us that its gene is important.

Scientists repeat each group more than one time. Each repeat is a **replicate**. Each sample that the machine reads is a **library**. In this guide, we use four libraries: two control replicates and two drug replicates.

The data

The machine gives two numbers for each library:

- the read count of our guide, and
- the total read count of all guides in that library.

Table 1 shows the data for one guide. We use these numbers in all sections of this guide.

What the symbols mean

K	The read count of one guide in one library. Library 1 has $K = 180$.
N	The total read count of all guides in one library. Library 1 has $N = 1{,}000{,}000$.
i	The library number (1, 2, 3 or 4). We write K_i for the count in library i. So $K_2 = 240$.

Table 1: Read counts for one guide in four libraries.

Library	Group	Guide count K	Total count N
1	control	180	1,000,000
2	control	240	1,200,000
3	drug	120	1,000,000
4	drug	80	800,000

Remember

Always record N before you remove any guides from the table. If you remove guides first, the totals become wrong. Then all the later numbers become wrong too.

Step 1: Turn counts into proportions

Library 2 has more reads than library 1 because the machine read it more. So we cannot compare raw counts. We divide each count by its library total. The result is a **proportion**:

$$p = \frac{K}{N}.$$

Proportions are very small numbers. So we multiply by one million. The result is the count **per million** reads.

Worked example 1: proportions

Library 1: $p = 180 \div 1{,}000{,}000 = 0.000180$ = 180 per million
Library 2: $p = 240 \div 1{,}200{,}000 = 0.000200$ = 200 per million
Library 3: $p = 120 \div 1{,}000{,}000 = 0.000120$ = 120 per million
Library 4: $p = 80 \div 800{,}000 = 0.000100$ = 100 per million

The two control libraries give 180 and 200 per million. The two drug libraries give 120 and 100 per million. The guide is less common with the drug.

What the symbols mean

p The proportion of all reads that belong to the guide. It is always between 0 and 1.

Step 2: Compare the groups with a fold change

We want one number that tells how much the guide changes. First, we combine the replicates of each group. We add their counts and add their totals:

$$p_{\text{control}} = \frac{180 + 240}{1{,}000{,}000 + 1{,}200{,}000} = \frac{420}{2{,}200{,}000} = 0.000191 \text{ (191 per million)},$$

$$p_{\text{drug}} = \frac{120 + 80}{1{,}000{,}000 + 800{,}000} = \frac{200}{1{,}800{,}000} = 0.000111 \text{ (111 per million)}.$$

The **fold change** is the drug proportion divided by the control proportion:

$$\text{fold change} = \frac{p_{\text{drug}}}{p_{\text{control}}} = \frac{0.000111}{0.000191} = 0.58.$$

A fold change of 0.58 means that the guide keeps only 58% of its control level. It loses 42%.

Remember

- Fold change $= 1$: no change.
- Fold change < 1: the guide becomes rarer. Cells may need this gene.
- Fold change > 1: the guide becomes more common. Losing this gene may help the cells.

Logarithms make changes symmetric

A fold change of 2 means "double". A fold change of 0.5 means "half". These changes have the same size, but the numbers 2 and 0.5 do not look equal. A **logarithm** fixes this problem.

The **base-2 logarithm**, $\log_2$, tells how many times you double.

Fold change	0.25	0.5	1	2	4
$\log_2$(fold change)	-2	-1	0	1	2

Now "double" is $+1$ and "half" is -1. The sizes look equal.

Worked example 2: log fold change

Our fold change is 0.58. It is between 0.5 and 1. So $\log_2(0.58)$ is between -1 and 0.
A calculator gives $\log_2(0.58) = -0.78$.
The guide drops by 0.78 "halvings".

BARCS uses the **natural logarithm**, ln. It counts powers of the number $e = 2.718\ldots$ instead of powers of 2. The idea is the same. To change back from ln, you raise e to that power: if $\ln(x) = b$, then $x = e^b$. For our guide, $\ln(0.58) = -0.54$.

Step 3: Odds and log-odds

BARCS works with **odds** instead of proportions. The odds compare the reads that belong to the guide with the reads that do not:

$$\text{odds} = \frac{p}{1-p}.$$

The **log-odds** is the natural logarithm of the odds:

$$\text{log-odds} = \ln\left(\frac{p}{1-p}\right).$$

Worked example 3: odds and log-odds

Control: $p = 0.000191$. So odds $= 0.000191 \div 0.999809 = 0.000191$.
The odds and the proportion are almost equal. This is true for all small proportions, because $1 - p$ is almost 1.
Log-odds for control: $\ln(0.000191) = -8.56$.
Log-odds for drug: $\ln(0.000111) = -9.10$.
Difference: $-9.10 - (-8.56) = -0.54$.
The difference of the log-odds is -0.54. This is the same as ln(fold change) from Step 2.

Remember

For guides, a difference in log-odds is almost exactly the natural log of the fold change. So you can read BARCS results as log fold changes.

Why use log-odds at all? A proportion must stay between 0 and 1. A log-odds can be any number, positive or negative. This property lets BARCS add effects together safely, as Step 5 shows.

Step 4: Two kinds of noise

The two control libraries gave 180 and 200 per million. They are not equal. Replicates always differ a little. We call this difference **noise**. BARCS must know how big the noise is. Then it can tell a real change from a chance change.

Guide counts have two kinds of noise:

1. **Counting noise.** The machine reads a random sample of all the guides. Think of a bag with a million marbles. You take out a handful. You do not get exactly the same number of red marbles each time.
2. **Biological noise.** Each replicate is a different group of living cells. The cells grow a little differently each time.

BARCS measures the size of the noise with the **variance**. The variance is the average squared distance of a value from its expected value. The **standard deviation** is the square root of the variance. It is the typical distance in the same units as the counts.

BARCS uses this formula for the variance of a guide count:

$$\text{variance} = \underbrace{N\,\mu\,(1-\mu)}_{\text{counting noise}} \times \underbrace{\big(1+(N-1)\,\rho\big)}_{\text{extra biological noise}}.$$

What the symbols mean

μ	"mu". The true proportion of the guide that we expect. For the control group, our best value is $\mu = 0.000191$.
N	The library total, as before.
ρ	"rho". A number that measures the biological noise. If $\rho = 0$, only counting noise exists. A bigger ρ means more biological noise.

Worked example 4: variance

Use N = 1,000,000 and μ = 0.000191. For our guide, BARCS estimates ρ = 0.000000386.
Counting noise: $N\mu(1-\mu) = 1{,}000{,}000 \times 0.000191 \times 0.999809 = 191$.
Extra factor: $1 + (N-1)\rho = 1 + 999{,}999 \times 0.000000386 = 1.39$.
Total variance: $191 \times 1.39 = 265$.
Standard deviation: $\sqrt{265} = 16.3$ reads.
So a count of about 191 normally moves up or down by about 16. Biological noise adds 39% to the counting noise.

Remember

Look at the extra factor $1 + (N-1)\rho$. It contains N. When the machine reads more, N grows, and the factor grows too. So more reading does not remove biological noise. Only more replicates help with biological noise.

Step 5: The design matrix

A **model** is a rule that predicts a value. BARCS predicts the log-odds of a guide in each library. The model needs to know which group each library belongs to. BARCS gets this information from the **design matrix**.

What a design matrix is

A design matrix is a table of numbers. It has:

- one **row** for each library, and
- one **column** for each β value in the model.

We write the design matrix with the letter X.

For our four libraries, the model has two β values. So X has four rows and two columns:

Library	Group	Column 1: "intercept"	Column 2: "drug"
1	control	1	0
2	control	1	0
3	drug	1	1
4	drug	1	1

What the symbols mean

X	The design matrix. One row for each library, one column for each β.
Intercept	A column of 1s. It belongs to β_0, the starting level. Every library gets the starting level.
Drug	A column that is 1 for a drug library and 0 for a control library. It belongs to β_1, the effect of the drug.
β_0	"beta zero". The log-odds of the guide in the control group.
β_1	"beta one". The change in log-odds from control to drug. This is the **effect**. It is the most important number.

From the design matrix to a prediction

To get the prediction for one library, take the row of that library. Multiply each number in the row by its β. Then add the products:

$$\text{predicted log-odds} = (\text{column 1}) \times \beta_0 + (\text{column 2}) \times \beta_1.$$

This calculation is a **matrix multiplication**. You do it one row at a time. We call the predicted log-odds η ("eta").

Worked example 5: predictions from the design matrix

BARCS finds $\beta_0 = -8.565$ and $\beta_1 = -0.542$ (Step 6 in Chapter 2 shows how).

Library 1 (row 1, 0): $1 \times (-8.565) + 0 \times (-0.542) = -8.565$
Library 2 (row 1, 0): $1 \times (-8.565) + 0 \times (-0.542) = -8.565$
Library 3 (row 1, 1): $1 \times (-8.565) + 1 \times (-0.542) = -9.107$
Library 4 (row 1, 1): $1 \times (-8.565) + 1 \times (-0.542) = -9.107$

The control libraries get β_0 only. The drug libraries get $\beta_0 + \beta_1$. So β_1 is the difference between the groups.

From log-odds back to counts

A prediction in log-odds is hard to read. So we change it back into a proportion, and then into a count. The rule is:

$$\mu = \frac{e^{\eta}}{1 + e^{\eta}}, \qquad \text{expected count} = N \times \mu.$$

This rule undoes the log-odds of Step 3.

Worked example 6: expected counts

Control libraries ($\eta = -8.565$): $e^{-8.565} = 0.000190676$. Then $\mu = 0.000190676 \div 1.000190676 = 0.000190640$, which is 190.6 per million.
Drug libraries ($\eta = -9.107$): $e^{-9.107} = 0.000110840$. Then $\mu = 0.000110827$, which is 110.8 per million.

Library	N	μ (per million)	Expected count $N\mu$	Real count K
1	1,000,000	190.6	190.6	180
2	1,200,000	190.6	228.8	240
3	1,000,000	110.8	110.8	120
4	800,000	110.8	88.7	80

The expected counts are near the real counts. The differences are -10.6, $+11.2$, $+9.2$ and -8.7 reads. These differences are the noise.

The reference group

The control group has 0 in the drug column. So control is the **reference group**. The effect β_1 always compares a group with the reference group. If you make drug the reference group, β_1 changes sign. It becomes $+0.542$. The meaning stays the same.

Paired replicates: add a column

Sometimes the replicates are pairs. For example, replicate 1 of control and replicate 1 of drug come from the same batch of cells. Then BARCS can remove the batch difference. You add a column for the batch:

Library	Group	Replicate	Intercept	Replicate 2	Drug
1	control	1	1	0	0
2	control	2	1	1	0
3	drug	1	1	0	1
4	drug	2	1	1	1

Now the model has three β values: the starting level, the batch difference and the drug effect. Each new column costs one degree of freedom (Step 8 in Chapter 2). With four libraries and three columns, only one degree of freedom stays.

Worked example 7: the paired model for our guide

BARCS gives the drug effect $\beta = -0.544$ with standard error 0.143. The effect is almost the same as before (-0.542). But the degrees of freedom drop from 2 to 1. The p-value becomes 0.164 instead of 0.033.
Our two replicates have almost no batch difference ($\beta = 0.005$). So the extra column costs information and gives nothing back. Add a batch column only when the replicates really are pairs.

Numbers instead of groups

A column can also hold a number, for example the day of the experiment. Suppose that you collect cells on day 0, day 7 and day 14, two libraries each. You put the day divided by 14 into a column:

Library	Day	Intercept	Day ÷ 14
1, 2	0	1	0
3, 4	7	1	0.5
5, 6	14	1	1

Now β_1 is the change in log-odds over 14 days. The model draws a straight line through the three days.

Worked example 8: a time course

Suppose that $\beta_1 = -0.70$.
After 14 days: change $= 1 \times (-0.70) = -0.70$. Fold change $= e^{-0.70} = 0.50$. The guide drops to half.
After 7 days: change $= 0.5 \times (-0.70) = -0.35$. Fold change $= e^{-0.35} = 0.70$. The guide drops to 70%.
The model has 6 libraries and 2 columns. So it has $6 - 2 = 4$ degrees of freedom.

Two factors and an interaction

Some experiments change two things. For example, cells can be normal or can have a second gene switched off (“knockout”). And cells can get no drug or the drug. This experiment has four groups. The design matrix has four columns:

Group	Intercept	Knockout	Drug	Knockout × Drug
normal, no drug	1	0	0	0
knockout, no drug	1	1	0	0
normal, drug	1	0	1	0
knockout, drug	1	1	1	1

The last column is the product of the knockout column and the drug column. It is 1 only when both are 1. Its β is the **interaction**. The interaction measures the extra change that happens only when both changes happen together.

Worked example 9: reading an interaction

Suppose that the four β values are -8.5, -0.2, $+0.1$ and -0.7. Multiply each row by the β values and add:

normal, no drug: -8.5

knockout, no drug: $-8.5 + (-0.2) = -8.7$

normal, drug: $-8.5 + 0.1 = -8.4$

knockout, drug: $-8.5 + (-0.2) + 0.1 + (-0.7) = -9.3$

The knockout alone changes the log-odds by -0.2. The drug alone changes it by $+0.1$. If the two effects only added up, the last group would be $-8.5 - 0.2 + 0.1 = -8.6$. The real value is -9.3. The extra -0.7 is the interaction. The guide drops strongly only when both changes happen.

Comparing two treatments: a contrast

Suppose an experiment has three groups: control, drug A and drug B. The design matrix has the columns intercept, drug A and drug B. Then β_A compares drug A with control, and β_B compares drug B with control. To compare drug A with drug B, you subtract: $\beta_A - \beta_B$. This calculation is a **contrast**. In BARCS, the function `bb_contrast()` calculates it and its test.

For example, if $\beta_A = -0.9$ and $\beta_B = -0.4$, then $\beta_A - \beta_B = -0.5$. Drug A lowers the guide more than drug B.

Rules for a good design matrix

1. Make one row for each library, in the same order as the count table.
2. Make one column for each β that you want.
3. Keep more rows than columns. The difference is the degrees of freedom. Two or more is better than one.
4. Do not let two columns carry the same information. For example, suppose that all drug libraries come from batch 2. Suppose also that all control libraries come from batch 1.

Then the batch column and the drug column are equal. BARCS cannot separate the drug effect from the batch effect.

The design matrix in R

In R, you describe the design matrix with a **formula**. The formula `~ group` means "an intercept and a column for each group except the reference group".

The function `model.matrix()` builds X from the formula:

```
> data <- data.frame(group = c("control", "control", "drug", "drug"))
> model.matrix(~ group, data)
  (Intercept) groupdrug
1           1         0
2           1         0
3           1         1
4           1         1
```

Then you give the counts, the totals, the formula and the column name to BARCS:

```
fit <- bb_screen(counts, data, formula = ~ group,
                 term = "groupdrug", totals = totals)
```

For the paired design, use the formula `~ replicate + group`. For the interaction, use `~ knockout * drug`.

Chapter 1 summary

Chapter 1 showed what BARCS measures and how it describes an experiment:

1. It turns read counts into proportions (Step 1).
2. It compares groups with a fold change and its logarithm (Step 2).
3. It works on the log-odds scale (Step 3).
4. It separates counting noise from biological noise (Step 4).
5. It describes the experiment with a design matrix (Step 5).

Chapter 2 shows how BARCS calculates the effect and decides if it is real.

The symbols of Chapter 1

Symbol	Meaning	Value in our example
K	read count of the guide in one library	180, 240, 120, 80
N	total read count of one library	1.0, 1.2, 1.0, 0.8 million
p	proportion, K/N	191 and 111 per million
fold change	$p_{\text{drug}} \div p_{\text{control}}$	0.58
$\log_2$	number of doublings	$\log_2(0.58) = -0.78$
ln	natural logarithm (powers of $e = 2.718$)	$\ln(0.58) = -0.54$
log-odds	$\ln(p/(1-p))$	-8.56 (control)
μ	expected proportion	0.000191 (control)
ρ	biological noise	0.000000386
X	design matrix: a row per library, a column per β	4 rows, 2 columns
β_0	control log-odds in the model	-8.565
β_1	effect of the drug	-0.542
η	predicted log-odds of a library (row of X times β)	-8.565, -9.107

Quiz for Chapter 1

Choose the best answer. The answers and calculations are on the next pages.

Q1. What does one guide do in a CRISPR screen?

(A) It counts the cells.

(B) It adds a drug to the cells.

(C) It reads the DNA.

(D) It switches off one gene.

Q2. A library has $K = 300$ and $N = 1{,}500{,}000$. What is the count per million?

(A) 200

(B) 300

(C) 450

(D) 500

Q3. Why do we divide each count by its library total N?

(A) To make the numbers bigger.

(B) Because the machine reads some libraries more than others.

(C) To remove the biological noise.

(D) Because BARCS cannot use whole numbers.

Q4. A guide has 400 per million in control and 100 per million with a drug. What is the fold change?

(A) 4

(B) 0.4

(C) 0.25

(D) 300

Q5. What is $\log_2(8)$?

(A) 2

(B) 3

(C) 4

(D) 8

Q6. A gene has $\log_2(\text{fold change}) = -1$. What happened to its guide?

(A) It doubled.

(B) It did not change.

(C) It dropped to half.

(D) It dropped to zero.

Q7. For a very small proportion p, which statement is true?

(A) The odds are almost equal to p.

(B) The odds are almost equal to 1.

(C) The odds are twice p.

(D) The odds are always 0.

Q8. In the variance formula, what does $\rho = 0$ mean?

(A) There is no noise at all.

(B) There is only counting noise.

(C) There is only biological noise.

(D) The guide has zero reads.

Q9. Use $N\mu(1-\mu)$ with $N = 100$ and $\mu = 0.5$. What is the counting variance?

(A) 25

(B) 50

(C) 0.25

(D) 100

Q10. The machine reads each library ten times more deeply. What happens to the biological noise?

(A) It disappears.

(B) It becomes ten times smaller.

(C) It does not go away. Only more replicates help.

(D) It becomes zero for control guides.

Q11. In the design matrix of our example, which β belongs to the column of 1s?

(A) β_1

(B) the interaction

(C) β_0

(D) ρ

Q12. BARCS gives $\beta_1 = 0.69$ for a guide. Use $e^{0.69} = 2.0$. What does this mean?

(A) The guide halves with the drug.

(B) The guide does not change.

(C) The guide disappears.

(D) The guide doubles with the drug.

Q13. An experiment has 3 control libraries and 3 drug libraries. The formula is `~ group`. What is the size of the design matrix?

(A) 3 rows and 2 columns

(B) 6 rows and 2 columns

(C) 2 rows and 6 columns

(D) 6 rows and 3 columns

Q14. A library has the row $(1, 1)$ in the design matrix. The values are $\beta_0 = -8.0$ and $\beta_1 = -0.5$. What is the predicted log-odds?

(A) -8.5

(B) -8.0

(C) -7.5

(D) 4.0

Q15. In the knockout-and-drug design, which group has a 1 in the interaction column?

(A) normal, no drug

(B) knockout, no drug

(C) normal, drug

(D) knockout, drug

Q16. You add a paired-replicate column to the model of our four libraries. How many degrees of freedom stay?

(A) 3

(B) 2

(C) 4

(D) 1

Answers for Chapter 1

Q1. D. Each guide switches off one gene (Section 1).

Q2. A. $300 \div 1{,}500{,}000 = 0.0002$. Then $0.0002 \times 1{,}000{,}000 = 200$ per million.

Q3. B. Libraries get different numbers of reads. Division by N makes them comparable (Step 1).

Q4. C. $100 \div 400 = 0.25$. The guide keeps one quarter of its control level.

Q5. B. $2 \times 2 \times 2 = 8$. You double three times, so $\log_2(8) = 3$.

Q6. C. -1 means one halving (Step 2).

Q7. A. $1 - p$ is almost 1, so $p/(1 - p)$ is almost p (Step 3).

Q8. B. The extra factor becomes $1 + (N - 1) \times 0 = 1$. Only counting noise stays (Step 4).

Q9. A. $100 \times 0.5 \times (1 - 0.5) = 100 \times 0.5 \times 0.5 = 25$.

Q10. C. The factor $1 + (N - 1)\rho$ grows with N. Deeper reading does not remove biological noise (Step 4).

Q11. C. The column of 1s is the intercept. It belongs to β_0, the starting level (Step 5).

Q12. D. The fold change is $e^{0.69} = 2.0$. The guide doubles.

Q13. B. One row for each library ($3 + 3 = 6$). One column for the intercept and one for drug (Step 5).

Q14. A. $1 \times (-8.0) + 1 \times (-0.5) = -8.5$ (Step 5).

Q15. D. The interaction column is knockout times drug. Only $1 \times 1 = 1$ (Step 5).

Q16. D. The model now has 3 columns. So df $= 4 - 3 = 1$ (Step 5).